α-$BaCu_2Se_2$ Thin-Film XRD Analysis and Bayesian Optimization

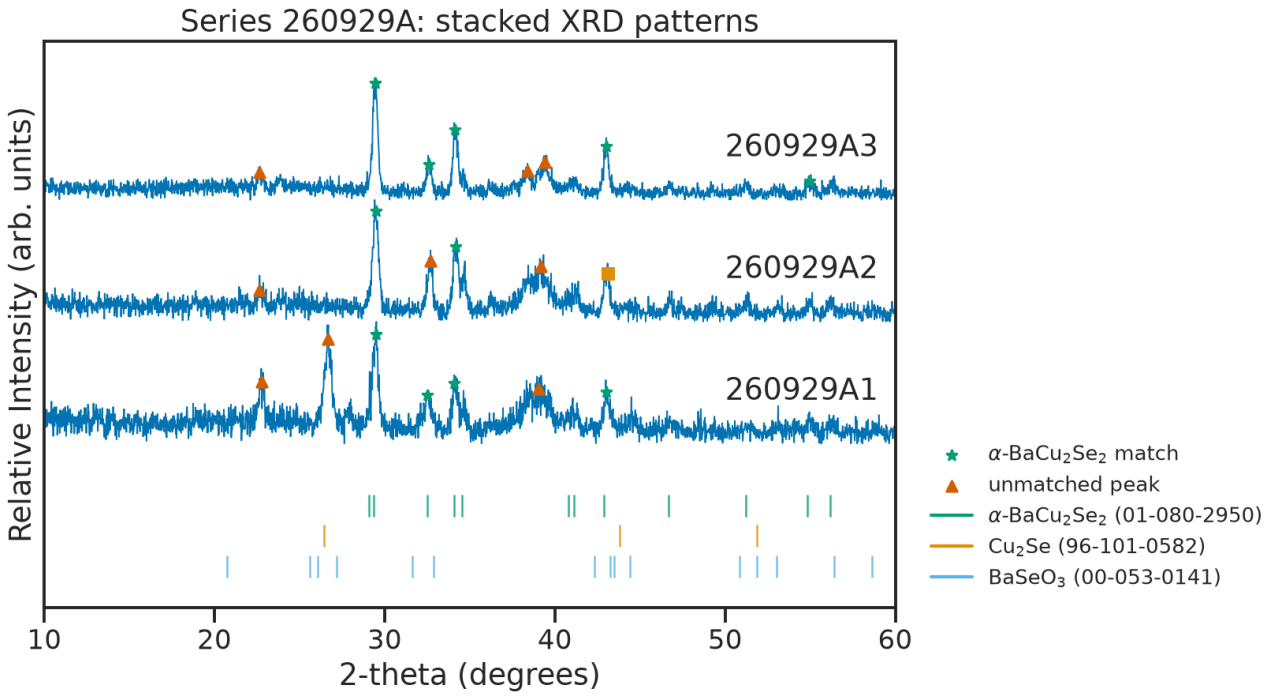
NOMAD-driven data extraction, phase matching, and GP-based synthesis planning

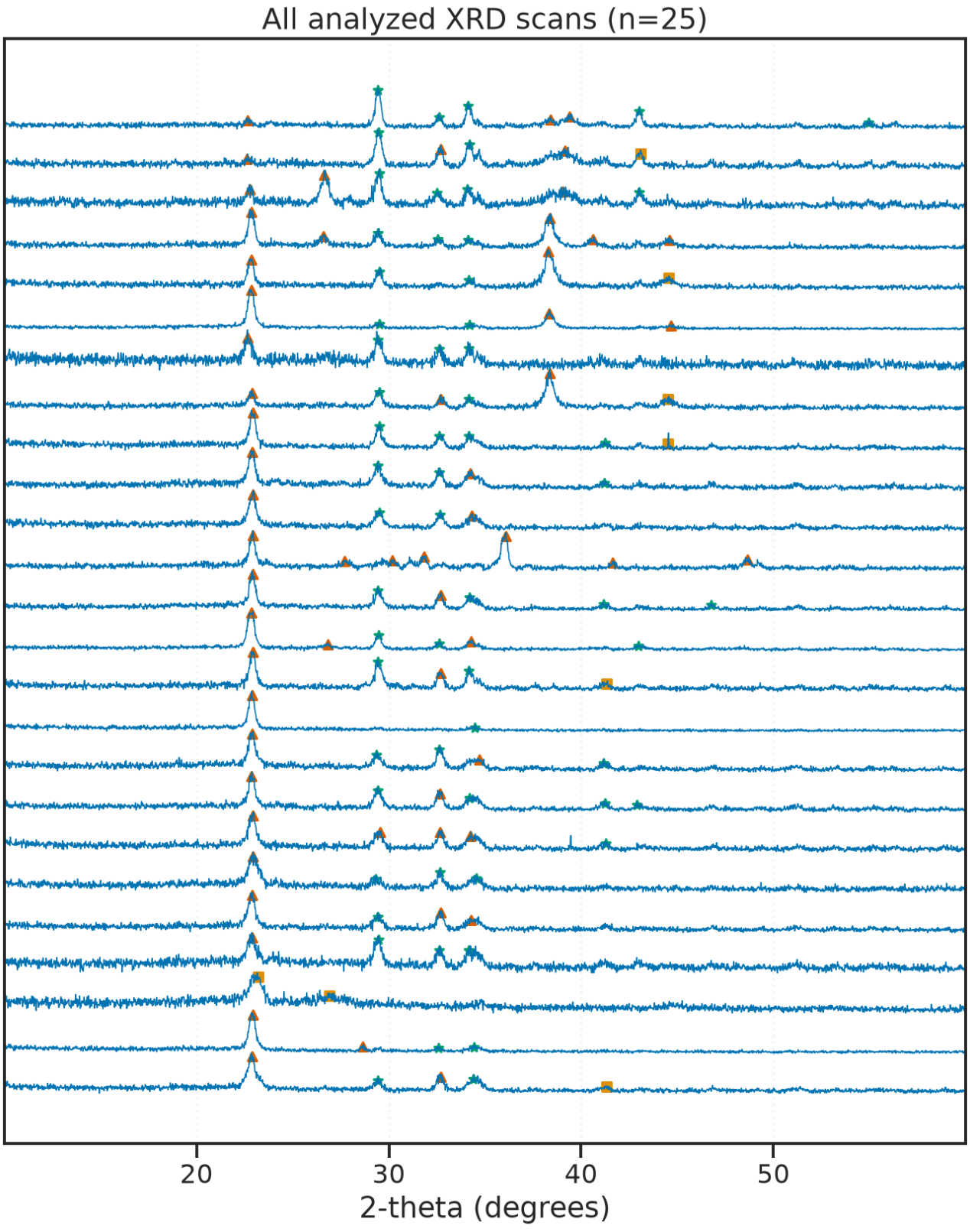
1. What was done

Synthesis records and XRD scans were pulled directly from the NOMAD Oasis REST API for the 42 α-$BaCu_2Se_2$ thin-film samples (INLThinFilmStack entries). Synthesis parameters (spin coating, soft/hard bake, selenization) and selenium-pulse settings were extracted for all samples; 35 include pulse on/off data. Each record also carries the precursor Cu/(Ba+Cu) ratio, the number of spin-coating cycles (deposited layers, excluding dynamic-dispense/seed-layer preparation steps), the Mo-coating flag, and the spin-to-selenization day gap. For the 25 films with XRD scans, diffraction patterns were matched against reference cards for the α-$BaCu_2Se_2$ target (01-080-2950), Cu_2Se (96-101-0582; α-Cu_2Se), and $BaSeO_3$ (00-053-0141). Phase purity and crystallinity (1/FWHM of the strongest target match) were computed per film. A Gaussian-process Bayesian optimizer was trained on the 21 complete films to recommend the next synthesis conditions, optimizing objective = (0.7 × phase purity + 0.3 × normalized crystallinity) × (1 – 0.25 × A) over a five-input space: hard-bake temperature, selenization temperature and time, Cu/(Ba+Cu) ratio, and continuous Se pulse duty cycle. The on+off period is fixed at 3200 ms (3.2 s), so pulse frequency is fixed at 0.3125 Hz and is reported as metadata, not optimized. Intermediate duty cycles are model interpolations from three observed levels and should be treated as exploratory; recommended on-times are quantized to 1 ms increments. CBC is defined as $n_{Cu}/(n_{Ba}+n_{Cu})$; the candidate grid is 0.63–0.71, so a ratio of 1 (no Ba) is excluded. A is the unmatched/overlap share of detected peak-interval area, a screening proxy—not a quantitative phase fraction or a confirmed assignment of the ~23° feature.

2. XRD phase identification

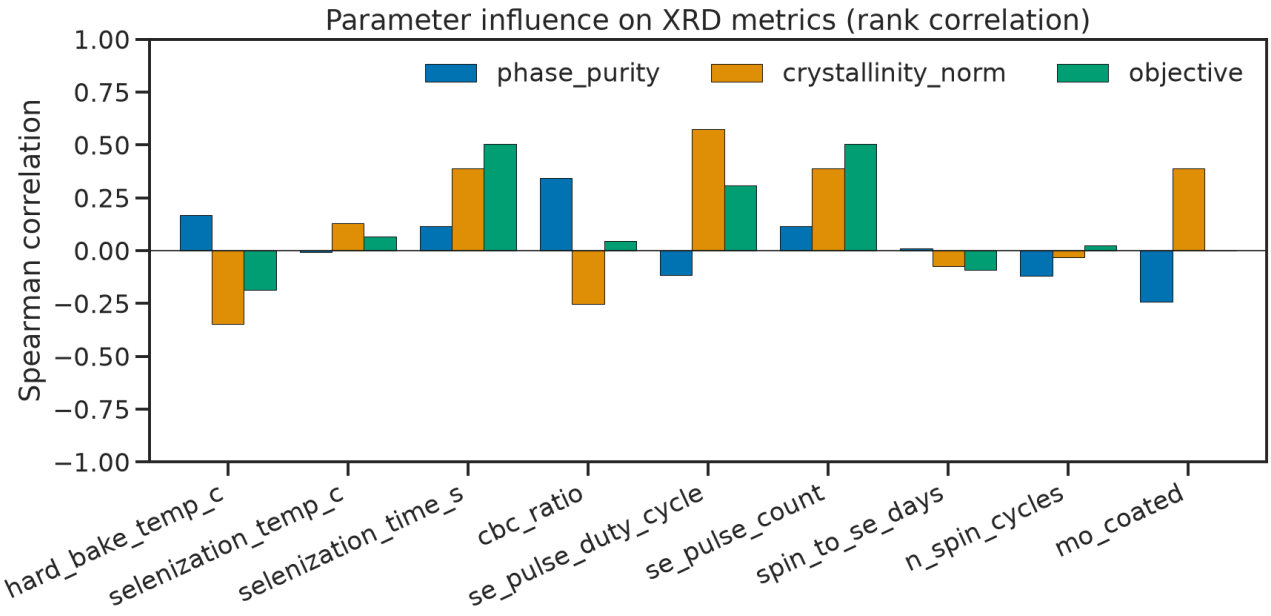
Stacked XRD patterns per series with reference bars for the target and impurity phases. Markers flag target (star), impurity (square), and unmatched (triangle) peaks.

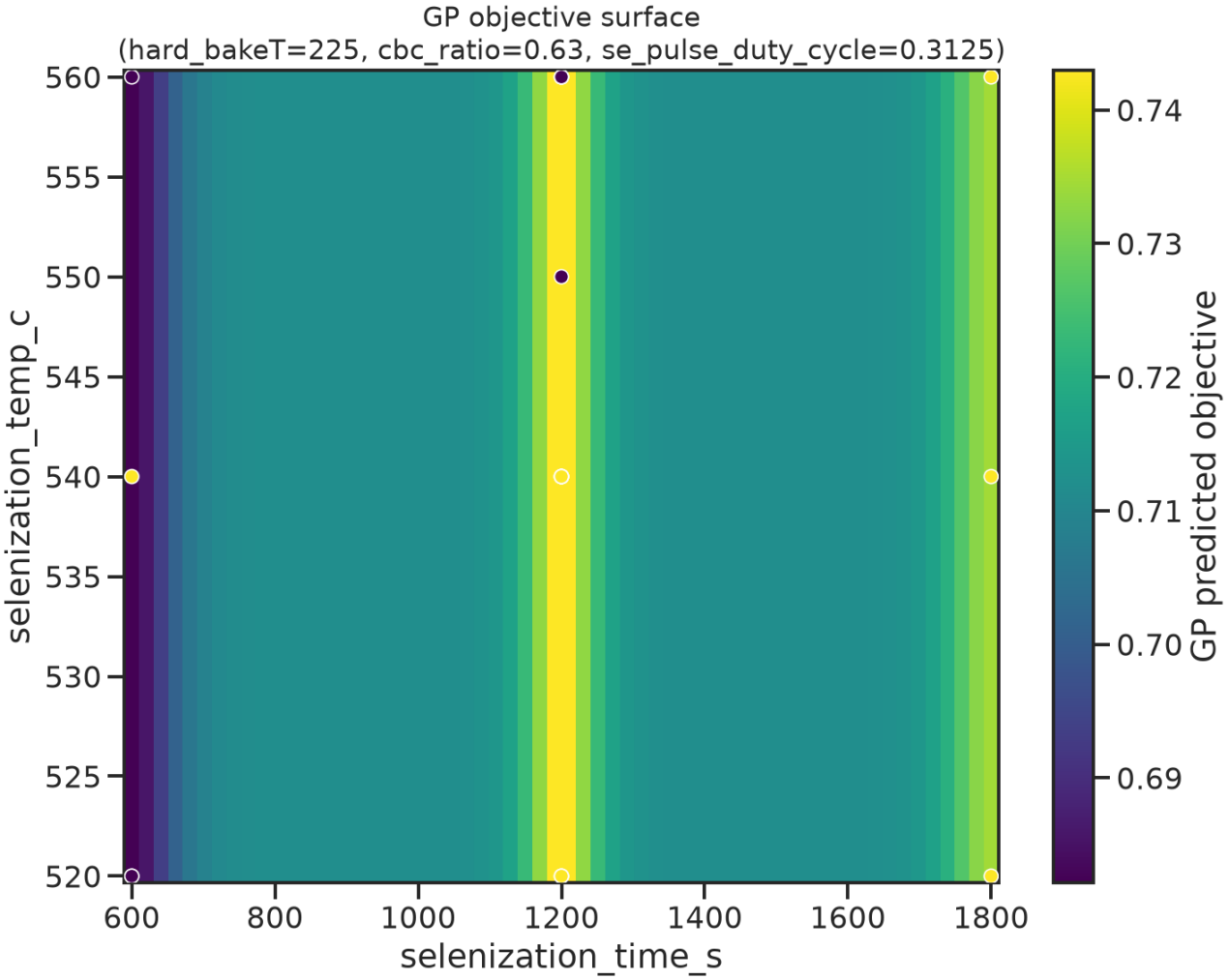




3. Main results

Across the analyzed films the mean phase purity is 0.94 and mean crystallinity is 2.18. The best film under the penalized score is 260929A3 (score 0.91; unpenalized score 0.99; purity 1.00, crystallinity 2.83, A 0.33). The optimizer uses the five selected inputs only. Other process and substrate descriptors remain available for descriptive exploration; duty cycle is modeled continuously, with the fixed pulse frequency excluded from the optimizer because it has no observed variation.



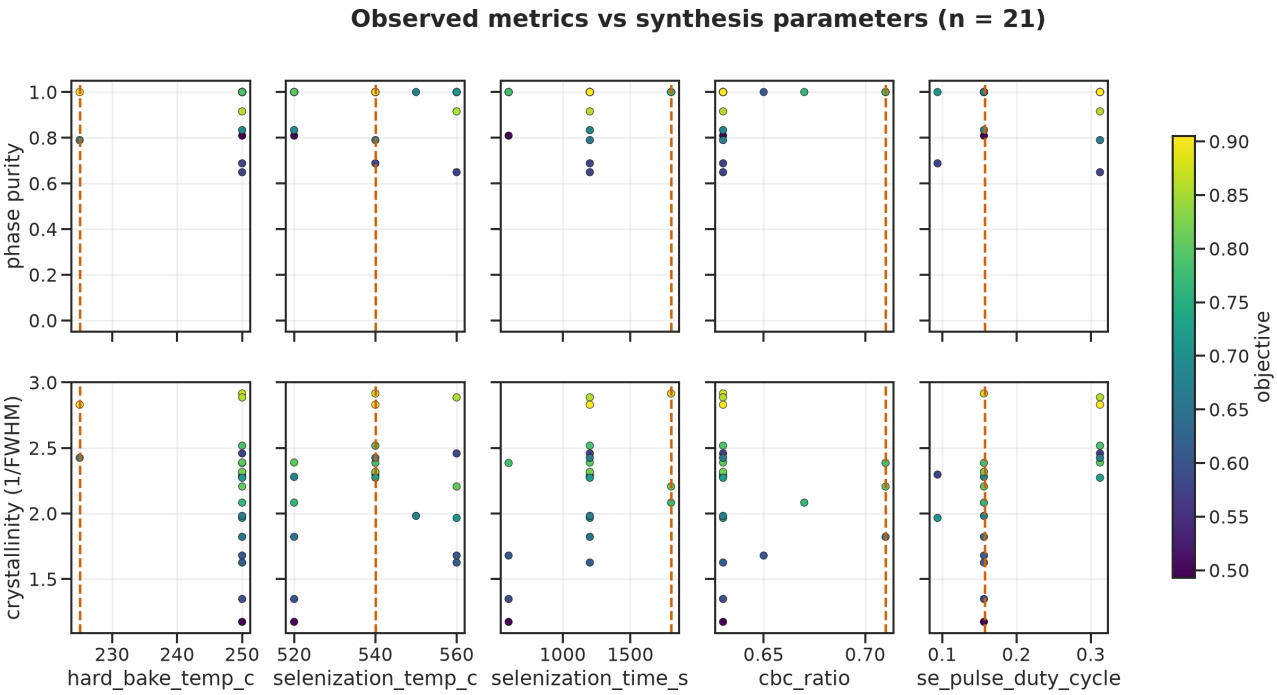


4. Suggested next experiments

Top Gaussian-process suggestions (predicted objective ± std), ranked by expected improvement:

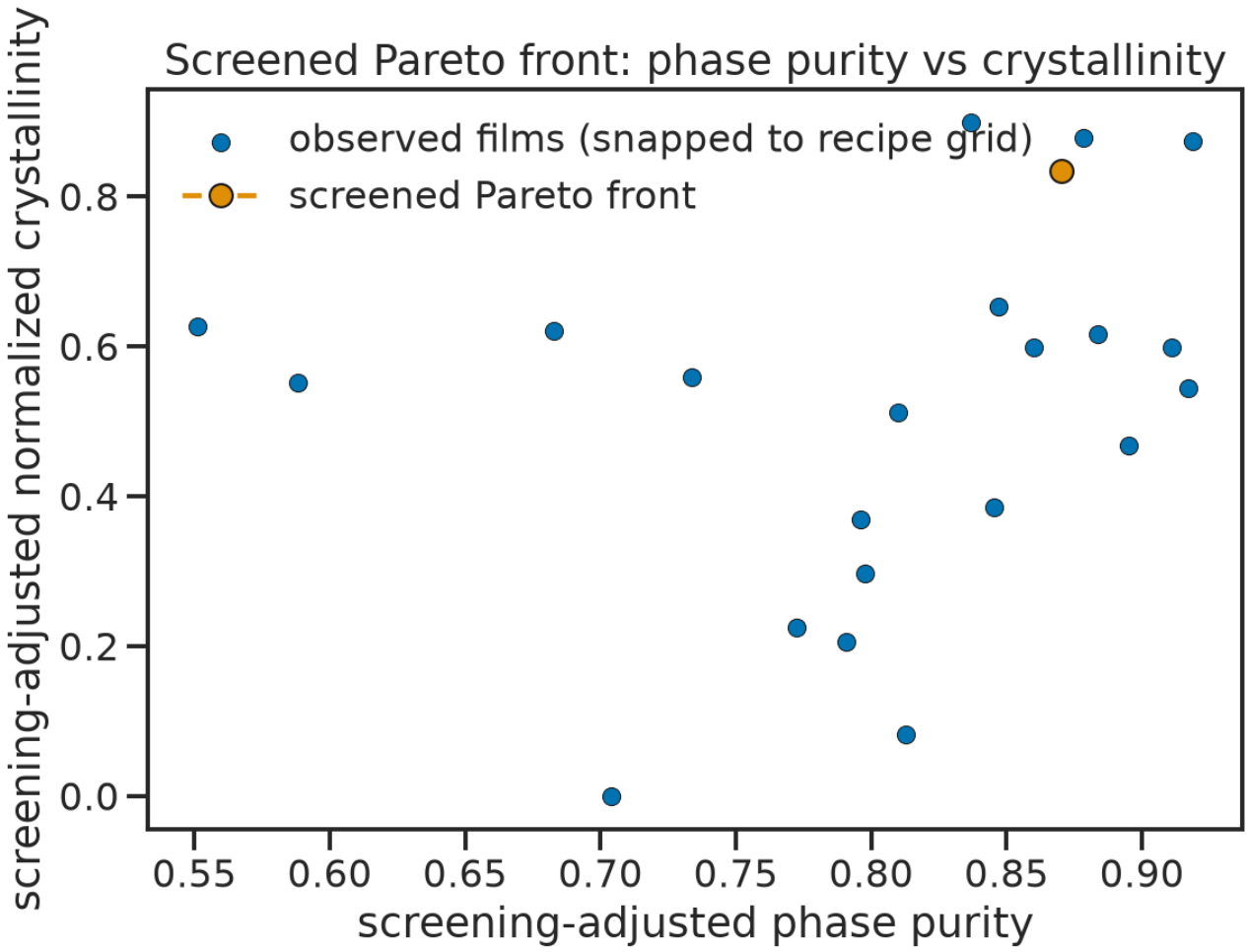
#	Hard bake °C	Selen. temp °C	Selen. time s	CBC ratio	Se duty cycle	Se on ms	Se off ms	Predicted score	GP std
1	225	540	1800	0.710	0.1575	504	2696	0.755	0.056
2	225	540	1800	0.630	0.1653	529	2671	0.712	0.062
3	225	540	1800	0.710	0.1675	536	2664	0.712	0.062
4	225	540	1800	0.650	0.1703	545	2655	0.712	0.062
5	225	540	1800	0.650	0.1728	553	2647	0.712	0.062

Recommended first experiment: hard bake 225 °C, selenization 540 °C for 1800 s, CBC ratio 0.710, and Se pulse duty cycle 0.1575 (504 ms on / 2696 ms off) (predicted objective 0.76).



5. Multi-objective optimization (Ax)

A complementary multi-objective search treats screening-adjusted phase purity and normalized crystallinity as two separate objectives: both are multiplied by the same (1 – 0.25 × A) factor. Ax (BoTorch) fits a Gaussian process per metric and finds the Pareto front via qNEHVI hypervolume maximization. Its five candidate inputs match notebook 3: hard-bake temperature, selenization temperature/time, CBC ratio, and continuous pulse duty cycle. Pulse period is fixed at 3.2 s (0.3125 Hz), so frequency is excluded as a constant. Duty-cycle suggestions are quantized to 1 ms on-time increments; interpolation between the three observed duty levels is exploratory. Numeric process recipes use the same explicit experiment-scale grids, including 25 °C bake steps. This remains a Pareto formulation, not the same scalar objective as notebook 3. A is an exploratory detected-peak-area screening proxy, not a phase fraction or a confirmed assignment of the ~23° feature.



#	Hard bake °C	Selen. temp °C	Selen. time s	CBC ratio	Se duty cycle	Se on ms	Se off ms
1	250	530	1800	0.630	0.1844	590	2610
2	225	540	1800	0.630	0.1622	519	2681
3	250	550	1800	0.650	0.1897	607	2593
4	225	530	1500	0.630	0.2425	776	2424
5	250	530	1800	0.630	0.1341	429	2771